

Primates

The primates are a family of mostly tree-dwelling animals that includes monkeys, apes, and ourselves. The first primates were small, squirrel-like animals that scampered around in the trees about the same time that the dinosaurs died out. Once the dinosaurs were gone, primates evolved into many new species, becoming larger and more intelligent over time.

Darwinius

dar-WIN-ee-us



- **When** 47 million years ago (Paleogene)
- **Fossil location** Germany
- **Habitat** Woodlands of western Europe
- **Length** 2 ft (0.6 m)
- **Diet** Fruit and plants

Only one fossil of *Darwinius* has been found: a skeleton, nicknamed “Ida,” so beautifully preserved that soft fur can be seen all over the body (left). Even Ida’s last meal of leaves and fruit was preserved in her stomach. *Darwinius* looked like a lemur. An agile climber, it had “opposable thumbs,” which means that its thumbs moved the opposite way to the fingers, allowing it to grasp branches and handle food.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Large brains
- Most had forward-facing eyes
- Grasping hands and feet
- Most had nails, not claws

When

The earliest primates appeared about 65 million years ago. Numerous species of primate still exist today.

